

2 The Facebook API

The Facebook API (or Application Programming Interface) is a set of software libraries that enable you to work with Facebook without knowing anything about its internal workings. All you have to do is obtain the client libraries, and start making use of them in your own application.

2.1 The classification

Facebook API calls are grouped into various action categories, each of which focuses on a different aspect of the Platform. These methods are really wrappers for more sophisticated FQL interactions with the Facebook back end but are useful bits of code that speed up the development of your application. Before we get into the details of these categories, let us look at some basic ones:

- `facebook.auth` - basic authentication checks for Facebook users.
- `facebook.feed` - post to Facebook news feeds.
- `facebook.friends` - query Facebook for various checks on a user's friends.
- `facebook.notifications` - send messages to users.
- `facebook.profile` - set FBML in a user's profile.
- `facebook.users` - information about your users (such as content from the user's profile and whether they are logged in).
- `facebook.events` - ways to access Facebook events.
- `facebook.groups` - access information for Facebook groups.
- `facebook.photos` - interact with Facebook photos.

Facebook consistently modifies these APIs as part of the REST API as new features are added, security issues are addressed, or behaviour deprecates or becomes obsolete.

Authentication API

The Facebook REST API has two methods `facebook.auth.createToken` and `facebook.auth.getSession` for dealing with authenticating your users. `facebook.auth.createToken` is the method that creates an authentication token (`auth_token`) that is then passed to the Facebook authentication mechanism. Once the user is logged in, the second method, `facebook.auth.getSession` will contain this token in the response if you specifically request the `auth_token` in the response.

Because Facebook takes responsibility for these actions, you don't have to take the headache of authentication and purchase SSL certifications,